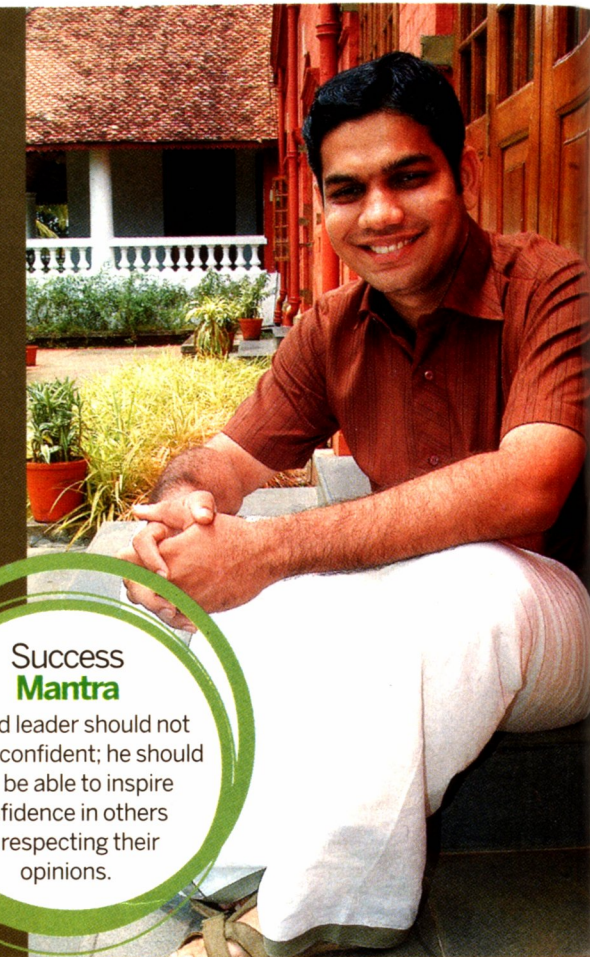


“STUDENT POLITICS IS DIFFICULT initially because of the lack of money. Only the resolute can pursue this path.”

HYBI EDEN, STUDENT LEADER, 26

When Rahul Gandhi took over the charge of the Youth Congress last year, he wanted to bring high-beam focus on reviving the National Students' Union of India (NSUI), the student wing of the Congress. And he chose NSUI's Kerala state unit president Hybi Eden for the task. Eden has already made his mark after being nominated as the NSUI's national president in December 2008 when he successfully held a conference in Uttarakhand where a president was elected, not nominated, for the first time in the 28-year history of the organisation. “The important task is to hold organisational elections in various units of the Youth Congress,”

says Eden, who was attracted to politics after joining the Sacred Heart College in Kochi. His father, George Eden, a Congress MP, had passed away when he was still in school. But Eden himself is a victim of the reluctance of political leadership to accept youngsters for top jobs. His bid to be the Congress' candidate in Kochi was thwarted by Congress veteran K.V. Thomas, who won the candidacy with his sustained courting of the high command with pickled prawns—or so the story goes. But Eden is not complaining. He knows that time is on his side. *by Shafi Rahman*



Success Mantra

A good leader should not just be confident; he should also be able to inspire confidence in others by respecting their opinions.

C SHANKAR

“THE YOUTH ALONE CANNOT HANDLE THE country. They have the ideas and the drive, but we need experience too.”

AMIT THAKER, POLITICIAN, 37

VIKRAM SHARMA



The youth will shun divisive politics based on caste and religion,” claims Amit Thaker, president of the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM)—a view quite unusual for someone belonging to the youth wing of the BJP, whose young face, Varun Gandhi, is hogging the limelight for divisive politics. He claims that young people are interested in development, and not casteism and that they feel strongly about politicians' children getting into the field without any grassroots experience. This young politician from Ahmedabad is a strong advocate of students' politics since “it is the only way young leadership can emerge”.

Coming from a family of RSS pracharaks, Thaker

has been attending shakhas since he was four. He is the first one in his family to be involved in active politics. “And probably, the last one too,” he smiles. Since the party work he does is voluntary, Thaker earns his living through the colleges he runs in Ahmedabad while his wife owns a chemical manufacturing unit.

Thaker was attracted to politics since his college days. His two-year tenure as the BJYM president has seen a record recruitment of as many as 30 lakh members. For the forthcoming elections, his youth wing will try to convince youngsters to come out and vote, not necessarily for the BJP. “But seeing our dedication, a number of them will become our voters,” he beams.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

Success Graph

Transformed the BJYM's women's wing Veerangana from a Vande Mataram-singing choir to a group that helps solve the problems of young girls.